Voting Weighted by Knowledge and IQ

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1. Introduction

In traditional democracy, each voter has exactly one vote, and all votes carry the same weight. This article starts from a simple question that each reader can answer for themselves:

Should the vote of a person with no education at all, or with a severe intellectual disability, carry the same weight as the vote of a Nobel laureate or a university professor?

Those who answer **yes** defend equal suffrage, and the model described here is not addressed to them. Those who answer **no** need an alternative, and this article proposes one: **Voting Weighted by Knowledge and IQ**, a new form of democracy in which the weight of a vote may vary according to the voter's performance on a test, always on an optional basis.

2. The model

Voting Weighted by Knowledge and IQ works according to the following rules:

1. **Optional test.** Each person may, if they wish, take a test that assesses (a) their level of general knowledge and (b) their intelligence.
2. **Record linked to the voter number.** The test result is stored in association with the person's voter number.
3. **Right to withdraw.** The person may withdraw and delete their score at any time.
4. **Standard weight.** Those who choose not to take the test keep a vote of fixed standard weight. No one loses the right to vote, and the individual weight of the vote of someone who does not take the test is not reduced, although their relative influence may decrease (section 2.3).
5. **Increased weight.** Those who choose to take the test and to use their score may have a vote worth more than that of someone who chose not to take it, up to a maximum limit, for example 50 times the weight of the standard vote.

2.1. Illustrative example

Let C be a person's general knowledge score and I their intelligence score, both normalized between 0 and 1. The composite score is $P = a \times C + b \times I$, with $a + b = 1$, and the principle of the model is that intelligence weighs more than knowledge, that

is, b > a (section 2.2). The weight of the vote grows linearly with P. As an example, with a = 0.2 and b = 0.8:

P = 0.2 × C + 0.8 × I

weight = 1 + 49 × P

Thus, someone who does not take the test or does not use their score has weight 1; someone who obtains C = 0.5 and I = 0.5 has P = 0.5 and weight 25.5; and someone who obtains C = 1 and I = 1 has the maximum weight, 50. The difference in weighting shows when comparing two people: with maximum knowledge and median intelligence (C = 1, I = 0.5), P = 0.6 and the weight is 30.4; with median knowledge and maximum intelligence (C = 0.5, I = 1), P = 0.9 and the weight is 45.1. ***The formulas above are only an example: the exact function, the proportions of 0.2 and 0.8, and the maximum limit are parameters yet to be defined. The limit of 50 times is only a reference***, and other limits are possible, as section 2.3 shows.

2.2. Why more weight on intelligence than on knowledge

The composite score gives greater weight to intelligence than to knowledge (80% versus 20% in the example) for two reasons.

The first is unequal access. General knowledge is acquired and depends on schooling, access to books and good teachers, and free time to study, factors that go along with income. A large weight on knowledge would tend to transfer political power to wealthier classes. Intelligence, measured by abstract reasoning tests that do not require school content, tends to depend less on these factors. It is not independent of them, because it also correlates with income and schooling. The weighting therefore reduces the problem but does not eliminate it.

The second reason is that knowledge should not be discarded. The main argument for giving more weight to certain voters is that better-informed voters choose better means for the ends they themselves hold (section 4). Knowledge therefore remains in the formula, with a lower weight, instead of being eliminated.

What the model defends is the principle that intelligence should carry more weight than knowledge. The values 0.2 and 0.8 are only an example, and other proportions, such as 0.3 and 0.7 or 0.4 and 0.6, respect the same principle. The appropriate proportion should be calibrated empirically, considering the relation of the score to the quality of the voter's information and its correlation with income.

2.3. Effect on the distribution of power

The standard weight guarantees that the vote of someone who does not take the test is worth no less than it is today. In relative terms, however, that voter's influence decreases as more people take the test and receive larger weights. For example, suppose that 10% of voters take the test and obtain an average of P = 0.5, while the remaining 90% keep weight 1. The share of total voting power held by the group that took the test would be:

- with a maximum limit of 50 times (average weight 25.5): about 74%;
- with a maximum limit of 10 times (average weight 5.5): about 38%;
- with a maximum limit of 5 times (average weight 3): 25%.

The maximum limit is therefore the parameter that controls the concentration of power, and it should be chosen with this effect in mind. The value of 50 times used in the examples is only illustrative.

3. Compatibility with the Jocaxian Democracy

Weighted voting can be combined with the Jocaxian Democracy (Barcellos, 2025). In that model, each person starts with one unit of representativeness, which is transferred to whoever receives their vote. In the combination, each person would start with their individual weight instead of 1, and the transfer of representativeness across the levels (block, district, city, state, and country) would remain the same.[01]

4. Objections and the model's responses

Equality of suffrage. The strongest objection is that equal suffrage is a principle in itself, not a means: every citizen is affected by political decisions and therefore has an equal right to influence them. *Response of the model:* the standard weight is preserved, no one is excluded, and the greater weighting is a voluntary choice of those who take the test. Even so, the relative influence of those who do not participate may decrease (section 2.3), which makes the maximum weight limit a central parameter of the model.

History of abuse. Literacy tests were used in the past to exclude entire groups from voting, as in the southern United States. *Response of the model:* here the test is optional and never eliminates anyone's vote; it can only add weight.

Test bias. Knowledge and IQ tests may reflect differences in schooling, income, and culture, and not only ability. *Response of the model:* the maximum weight limit reduces the effect of possible distortions, and weighting intelligence more heavily than knowledge (section 2.2) reduces, without eliminating, the advantage of classes with greater access to education. In addition, the test must be public, free of charge, auditable, and validated for the electoral population. Building such a test is a necessary condition of the model and an open question.

Self-selection. Because the test is optional, those who take it are not a random sample: the more educated, those more interested in politics, and organized groups that mobilize their members tend to join. The extra weight could reflect participation more than knowledge. *Response of the model:* the maximum weight limit restricts the effect of mobilization, and a free test and the publication of preparation material reduce inequality of access. The effect of self-selection can only be measured empirically, and it is a limitation of the model.

Knowledge is not good judgment. A high score in knowledge or intelligence does not guarantee good values or good political judgment, and highly educated people also vote out of interest or bias. *Response of the model:* the model does not claim that knowledge guarantees good values. Its thesis is narrower: part of political decision-making is empirical (what effects a policy will have, how an institution works), and in that part a better-informed voter tends to choose better means for the ends they themselves hold. There are estimates that electoral behavior changes systematically when the votes of fully informed voters are simulated (Bartels, 1996). In formal terms, when votes try to reach the same correct answer, weighting by competence improves the accuracy of the collective result, under certain assumptions such as independence among votes (Condorcet, 1785; Nitzan and Paroush, 1982). This applies only to the factual dimension of the choice. For the dimension of values, the model claims no superiority, which is why the weight is capped. Consequently, the test should include basic political and scientific knowledge, such as institutions, economics, and statistics, and not only general culture.

Privacy and data security. The score is sensitive personal data. *Response of the model:* the right to delete it at any time is part of the rules, but secure storage and confidentiality of the result must be guaranteed in implementation.

5. Conclusion

Voting Weighted by Knowledge and IQ is a form of democracy for those who understand that the weight of a vote can reflect, voluntarily and transparently, the voter's knowledge and intelligence. Its central points are optional participation, a guaranteed standard weight for those who do not take part, and a maximum limit on the increased weight, which controls the concentration of power, and a score that weights intelligence more than knowledge, to reduce the advantage of wealthier classes. The points that require further study are the construction and validation of the test, the weighting function, the effect of self-selection, and data protection; the proposal is a theoretical model, still without empirical evaluation.

Statement on the use of artificial intelligence

The ideas and the model presented in this article are the author's. The drafting of the text, the structuring of the sections, and the section on objections and responses, including the analysis of the effect on the distribution of power, were prepared with the assistance of the artificial intelligence assistant Claude (Anthropic) and reviewed by the author, who takes responsibility for the content.

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